

past, it will need the Self to come back to that time to do what it needed someone to do for it then. With each interaction, the Self earns more trust and license to lead. To begin creating a safe two-way connection with an exile, invite your client to try the following:

- Identify a vulnerable part.
- Guide a connection to the Self via imagery or activation.
- Check for Self-energy and reassure the part that it is not alone anymore.
- Send care and compassion to the part.
- Invite the part to share whatever it is holding.
- Witness and honor the part's experience.
- Spend time gazing at, reflecting with, and embracing the part.
- Reassure the part that you will return.

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WITNESSING AND UNBURDENING

Clients in therapy who are addressing extensive periods of substance use or other compulsive behavior may have episodes of intrusive imagery or sensations that relate to traumatic events in the past. These images and sensations often reflect exiled parts who are breaking through consciousness in an effort to get help. These parts have been burdened with bad memories, shocking feelings, and negative beliefs as a result of the traumatic event. Many of these beliefs have to do with being irreparably damaged, unlovable, shameful, or disgusting. These negative beliefs can operate unconsciously for decades, profoundly affecting the individual's view of themselves and the world. As a result, they show up in client stories repeatedly.

Sometimes a client's protectors will see the Self as just another part who doesn't have the capacity to tolerate exiled pain, causing their fear to shoot up whenever the client approaches an exile. They seem to be checking: *Are you really ready for this?* However, the reality is that the client's Self is ready to step in and reverse negative judgments about the part. It is ready to witness the exile's story, validate its experience, and assert its inherent value and lovability. When a client is Self-led, they show up alert and open-hearted, and exiles get the sustained care, understanding, and protection they've always needed. As a result, they let go of distorted perceptions about themselves and the world. The client who is present and compassionate to their own story will be liberated to know what they know, feel what they feel, and speak honestly without self-attack.

In this Self-led state, the client—and, if the exile wishes, the therapist—can bear witness to the exile's story through a process known as *witnessing*. Here, the exile may want to show or tell the Self about its experiences in detail, taking the Self to see a seminal scene; it may summarize its experience; or it may just say, "You know all this, I want to get out of here." In this portion of therapy, which occurs within the security of the therapeutic relationship, the exile is the director who guides the Self through its story, rather than reliving it in the same traumatic way. Our job is to stay fully present to the exile's story and do whatever it wants. Along the way, we prompt the client to acknowledge the exile as needed: "Let this sensitive part know you hear it" or "Let this college kid inside know you are paying attention and it is making sense."

In addition to being a compassionate witness to the exile's story, we have two main jobs as IFS therapists. The first is to be what we call a *parts detector*, who calms any protective parts who interrupt the story. If a protector is very anxious and keeps interrupting, we kindly but firmly ask it to step back and assure it that the exile only needs what it has always needed: a safe, secure, loving, and available relationship with someone they trust, and we are in the process of meeting its needs.

The second is to guide the client through the *unburdening* process by following these simple steps. First, we ask the exiled part if it needed help in the past. If so, the client's Self can go back and do for the part whatever it needed someone to do at the time, in a process known as a do-over. This trip through the past with the Self disconfirms the exile's negative beliefs about its identity. When the part is ready to leave the past, we invite it to come to the present and ask if it has burdens from that previous experience. If so, we invite the part to let go of those burdens or, if it is not yet ready to let go, to put the burdens in storage. If the part is ready, we ask how it would like to let its burdens go and suggest releasing them to one of the elements (light, earth, air, water, or fire^{*}), or in any way other that feels just right. Finally, we ask the part what it wants to invite in once the burdens have gone out, and we ask protectors to notice the new state of the now-unburdened former exile. Unburdening is the ceremonial capstone of witnessing.

THE THERAPIST'S ROLE IN WITNESSING AN EXILE AND HELPING IT UNBURDEN

Guide the client as they:

1. Offer to go back and help the part in the past.
2. Offer to help the part leave the past when it is ready.
3. Ask the retrieved part if it has burdens once it reaches the present.
4. Witness the part as it lets go of its burdens.
5. Help the part put its burdens in storage if it's not ready to let go.
6. Ask the part how it would like to release the burdens (light, earth, air, water, or fire).
7. Ask the part what it wants to invite in once the burdens have been released.
8. Ask protectors to notice the former exile who is now unburdened.

The following vignette is a good example of a client's Self bearing witness and joining with an agonized young part (and an exiled angry protector) in the past and making room for a do-over. At the time of this session, Margot was a twenty-nine-year-old Canadian American, single, bisexual, cisgender woman who had been coming to therapy for oxycontin and fentanyl use and posttraumatic stress disorder. During treatment, she had helped some bullying manager parts to calm down and some drug-using firefighters to find new roles. Now she was finally ready to help a four-year-old exile who was being molested by her father in the basement of her childhood house. The therapist and Margot had connected with this part in the past for many brief moments, letting her know she wasn't alone and that help was coming, and Margot had even taken her to a safe place. But she had discovered through flashbacks that the part was back in the basement again.

UNBURDENING AN EXILE



Therapist: Margot, can you see or sense the four-year-old now?

Margot: Yeah, I see her. I feel panicky and sick.

Therapist: Okay she's a little blended. Is it too much, or can you just let her know you're aware of her and we're here to help?

Margot: Uh, okay, yeah. I let her know we're here. But I feel the panic.

Therapist: Right, Margot, such a scary, awful place for this little one. You're feeling her feelings.

Margot: Yeah, she's scared shitless. She feels sick and I do too.

The exile is blending and beginning to overwhelm Margot.

Therapist: Of course. Let's take a breath together. (*They take breathing pause.*) Let her know that you feel her feelings and you're still here. You're just telling me about her.

The therapist pauses to facilitate enough unblending to continue safely.

Margot: Yeah. Okay, yeah. I'm here, we're here. Wow, is she panicking!

Therapist: How are you feeling toward her as she panics? Are you with her, or is the panic overwhelming?

Margot: Yeah okay... (*Her breathing slows.*) I'm okay. I'm here for her.

Therapist: Does she want to leave that place?

Margot: She does! She sure wants out!

Therapist: Okay, bring her to the present. She can be with us here or anywhere that feels safe.

Margot: Okay, she's here with me now. She's all curled up.

Therapist: Okay, let's pause, and send her your energy and breath. Let her get used to being with you now. (*The therapist pauses.*) She never has to go back. That time is over, and she can stay with you.

Margot: Right, yeah, okay. She's doing a little better. (*She leans back in her chair.*) She's happy to be with me.

Therapist: Okay, great. How are you feeling toward her?

Margot: Sad. He was terrible.

Therapist: Share that with her, Margot. Help her take in that you get it. Your heart is open to her. You know how hard it was for her to be captured by him.

Margot: Okay, she's moving closer to me.

Therapist: Great, stay with her. Let her feel you. When you're ready, ask if she needs to show or tell you anything about that time.

Margot: She says he hurt her, touched her. She was scared. She feels sick that she couldn't get away from him. (*She begins to get teary.*)

Therapist: Can you keep going? (*Margot nods.*) Let her know you're taking this in. Of course she felt sick and scared and wanted to escape. Does she feel you still?

Margot: Yes. She's showing me. (*She pauses.*) It happened too often. There's a lot. She hated him.

The exile returns to show her experience from the safety of the present.

Therapist: Of course she did. What does she need from you right now?

Margot: Just to show me.

Therapist: Okay. Can you stay with her? (*Margot nods.*) When she's ready, ask what that was like for her.

Margot: It was like his sickness got into her. (*She slightly curls over.*) I've always felt it in my gut.

Therapist: Let her know you feel it too. Would she like you to come to that time and do for her now what she needed someone to do then?

Margot: She wants me to tell him that he can never, ever touch her again! He's a sick motherfucker. He can rot in hell! I'm sure that's where he is.

Therapist: Here's an angry part.

Margot: Yeah, this part could rip him to shreds.

Therapist: Of course she could. (*The therapist pauses.*) Does that part object to you helping the little one?

Margot: No. They both want my help. I'm putting him out of the house. He's never getting his hands on her again. (*She takes a long pause.*) Yeah, he won't say it, but he's sorry. He knows something is wrong with him. He killed himself, so duh.

Therapist: (*The therapist pauses again.*) Do they feel you there with them?

Margot: Yeah.

Therapist: How is the little one doing?

Margot: She's glad I got rid of him, but she's back there again, curled up on the floor.

The exile has gone back to the past.

Therapist: Is his sickness still in her? (*Margot nods.*) Okay. It doesn't belong to her. If she doesn't want it, she can send it out.

Margot: She can't believe that. Anyway, she doesn't know how.

The exile has not successfully unburdened, which is why she returned to the past.

Therapist: I understand. It has been in her a long time. But since it's not hers, it can't stay if she wants it out. We can help with that when she's ready.

Margot: She says fine. Make it go!

Therapist: First we have to ask, are any of her other parts attached to it? Does any part of her want her to keep on carrying his sickness? (*Margot shakes her head no.*) Okay. Then she can send it out to one of the elements: light, earth, air, water, or fire. Or some other way if she prefers.

Margot: She wants the light of heaven.

Therapist: Great.

Margot: Okay. She steps into the light. Me too. I'm going with her. His sickness is like swirling ink in her gut, but the light is getting in to us now. (*She breathes evenly, cries a little, and holds her stomach.*) The light just draws it out... Oh wow, there's more.

Therapist: Take your time. (*They both take a long pause.*)

Margot: That's better. Now she's standing up, stretching her arms.

Therapist: What qualities does she want or need going forward? She can invite anything.

Margot: She wants innocence. She is not him; she is her.

Therapist: Innocence.

Margot: She's lighter, taller.

Therapist: How does that feel?

Margot: Perfect.

Therapist: Does she want to show you anything else, or want anything from you before we finish?

Margot: She's good. She wants to play with my dog, Tucker.

Therapist: Did the angry part see her sending the sickness out? (*Margot nods.*) Does she need anything from you before we stop?

Margot: She saw. She sees me. She's relieved. She wants to come and stay with me too.

Now the exile can leave the past for good.

Therapist: Excellent, Margot. I'm so glad they're with you now.



In IFS therapy, we invest in befriending protective parts and getting their permission to help exiles first, then we go to the exiles. Generally speaking, protectors take more time and evoke more frustration and intolerance in the therapist (requiring us to notice and help our parts on a regular basis), while exiles evoke more empathy (which can also be a trailhead if the therapist's empathizer is an exile), but it takes far less time once the therapist has access to their Self. It is the essence of acceptance to love fragile, wounded parts in ourselves and others.

Most clients with addictive processes, especially those with early traumatic experiences, struggle to know and accept themselves, with good reason. It's daunting to peer behind a phalanx of protectors and witness injury and insults from the past. These protective parts got into addictive processes to manage despair, and going back to the injured parts who are still in despair can feel like a bridge too far. Protectors don't want to face those terrible experiences with burdened young parts again. In the unburdening process, we befriend protectors and let them know that this difficult job no longer needs to fall on them. The Self can take charge instead. We say, "This isn't your job. Stay right here while the Self goes back to help that injured part and fetch it out—and then we'll help you too." The following example illustrates how this can look in practice.

Greta was a fifty-six-year-old, German American, married lesbian with a long history of substance use and other addictive behaviors. Her practices include drinking alcohol, taking amphetamines and various tranquilizers, and bingeing and purging. She worked with her wife, Carrie, at a high-powered firm and functioned well enough at work, but Greta felt chronically anxious and depressed and wanted to stop engaging in these self-destructive behaviors. Although Carrie accepted Greta's substance use and bulimia, Greta still hid some of the behaviors from her.

BEFRIENDING A PROTECTOR



Therapist: How is it going, Greta?

Greta's Firefighter: Another crazy week for me! Work is a fiasco. I'm like a hamster tied to a wheel. It's frigging depressing.

Therapist: Mm-hmm. Sounds hard. I hear your managers have come through for you again, which is great. But it also sounds like all that hard work is costing you some.

Greta's Firefighter: Well, if you mean I'm miserable, yes, I am! I can't sleep and I'm not eating right. So, I'm back to Valium. And I had some drinks and whatever. Then I was up eating at 3 a.m. So, all in all, I'm a mess.

Therapist: The firefighters are out in force to help. How does it feel to talk about that?

Greta's Firefighter: Work is hell. I can't sleep. So what am I gonna do?

Therapist: Right, I get it. I have an idea, though. How about we check in and see if we can connect with the firefighter team right now?

Greta's Firefighter: I don't know. I mean, I know why I'm doing it. I just need sleep!

Therapist: Right, there are some obvious reasons, for sure. Your managers are overworked and require help to settle down on the weekend.

Greta's Firefighter: (*She nods.*) Yeah, like I'm responsible for Carrie's entire workload while she's on maternity leave. And her job is above my pay grade for God's sake. I'm not supposed to be responsible for some of these things. I have no experience and I'll get blamed if I make a mistake. Which I'm bound to do.

Therapist: I get it. You need a break! In this circumstance, if I hear you right, the firefighter team is a bit more intense than usual? (*Greta nods.*) And that worries you?

Greta's Firefighter: Well, it's depressing. I don't want to go down this road again. But what am I gonna do?

Therapist: Right. It feels like there is nowhere else to turn. They get the job done! But I do think we could learn more about what exactly gets them so ramped up if we ask. They're doing a little more than just helping you relax, if I understand correctly.

Greta's Firefighter: (*She shrugs.*) Okay, okay.

Therapist: So, Greta, visualize these soother parts in action. Visualize whatever happened on Saturday. (*Greta is quiet.*) Can you see them? (*Greta nods.*) Where are you?

Greta: I'm in my bedroom. I've got the wine, I took some Valium, and I'm watching TV.

Therapist: Okay, this the main soother part. How do you feel toward her?

Greta's Manager: She looks deranged. I hate that I'm into Valium again!

Therapist: She's struggling. I hear that. And did you hear your judging part just now?

Greta's Manager: Yes. I do judge her. She's totally messed up. I can't even look at her. (*She opens her eyes and looks at the therapist.*)

Therapist: I know it's hard to see how checked out this part gets. (*The therapist pauses as they breathe together; Greta is tearful.*) I hear a part who feels sad about all this. (*Greta nods.*) So acknowledge the sad part. Of course she's sad! Would she give you space to hear from the soother? (*Greta frowns.*) The soother is very alone at those times, isn't she? (*Greta nods.*) You could help her, if the critic lets you. (*After a pause, Greta nods again.*) Let her know you see how alone she was on Saturday. But right now, she's not alone. You're there too.

Greta: (*She breathes a little more easily.*) She hates being alone.

Therapist: Let her know you get that. (*The therapist pauses.*) Greta, ask the soother what she's really after when she takes a lot of Valium. How is she trying to help?

Greta's Firefighter: She just wants me to get fucked up!

Therapist: Okay, got it! She wants you to get fucked up. But why now? What's going on now?

Greta's Firefighter: Because I'm always on. I never let up. I never stop worrying.

Therapist: Does that make sense to you? (*Greta nods.*) Let her know you get that too. And, also, that you are not the one who never lets up. There is a part who never lets up, for sure, but that's not you. And you're listening to her.

Greta's Firefighter: Okay, well she's not so sure about that.

Therapist: How do you feel toward her right now?

Greta's Firefighter: I feel good. She's good for me.

Therapist: Tell me more about the good feeling.

The therapist uses implicit direct access to talk with the soother.

Greta's Firefighter: Well, I feel like, yeah, I do need a break. I do need to feel relaxed once in a while, so what?

Therapist: Your body relaxes and you get that "who cares!" feeling that comes from being high. You can let go. And it's a relief?

Greta's Firefighter: I'm just saying it's not such a big deal. Who cares?

Therapist: You are the soother, right? You're reminding Greta of what's important about letting go. You help her.

The therapist switches to explicit direct access and speaks to the soother about Greta in the third person.

Greta's Firefighter: (*She laughs.*) I guess so.

Therapist: Greta, can you feel some gratitude for the soother? She finds ways to give you ease. She helps you let go and not worry so much. (*The therapist pauses.*) What is she afraid would happen if she didn't do this for you?

Greta: She thinks I'm a nervous wreck all the time, which is true.

Therapist: Right. Is she helping with anything else?

Greta: She says I don't feel good about myself and that I'm depressed. This job is just a total drag. They're using me and they'll never promote me.

Therapist: So the soother is aware of the part who doesn't know how to defend herself, is that right?

Greta: Yeah, that happens to me all the time. That's my life story!

Therapist: If we could help the part who gets hurt feel stronger and safer, would that be good for the soother?

Greta: Yeah, yeah, of course. If we could, that is. I mean, it's like my whole life.

Therapist: I know. She got hurt a long time ago and you keep getting hurt again. But if the hurt part had you taking care of her, would it help?

Greta: Yeah, it might.

Therapist: Will the hard worker and the soother let you do that? (*Greta nods.*) Okay, Greta. Let her know you're here. Tell her you know all about her and you want to help.

Greta: Wow. She's little!

Therapist: How old?

Greta: Around three.

Therapist: Does she see you? (*Greta nods.*) What does she need?

Greta: Me.

Therapist: What needs to happen?

Greta: I'm picking her up. She needs a hug.

Therapist: How do you feel toward her?

Greta: I love her.

Therapist: Does she need your help back then or is she ready to leave?

Greta: She wants me to tell her mother to back off and stop scaring her.

Therapist: Okay. Invite her mother's higher Self in to help her mother understand.

Greta: Yeah. Her mother needs a lot of help.

Therapist: And what does she need?

Greta: She wants to send her mother away and come with me. She wants to bring her baby sister. Is that okay?

Therapist: Whatever she wants. She's the boss.

Greta: She came to the present. We have the baby.

Therapist: Does she have any burdens from that time?

Greta: What do you mean?

Therapist: Ask her to check. Any feelings from that time that don't change, or beliefs she doesn't need anymore.

Greta: Oh yeah! She thought something was wrong with her.

Therapist: Is she ready to let that go?

Greta: Yes.

Therapist: She can give it up to light, earth, air, water, or fire. Or any way she wants.

Greta: Fire. We're burning it. The baby has some slime on her body. We wiped it off and we're burning the rag.

Therapist: How does that feel?

Greta: Light, fresh.

Therapist: Now what would she like to invite in that she'll need going forward?

Greta: She wants to play.

Therapist: Great. Invite the spirit of play and freedom. (*After a pause, Greta nods.*) Is it okay now to check back with the soother? (*Greta nods.*) How is she doing?

Greta: She's standing up. She looks more together. She wonders if this will work.

Therapist: What does she need?

Greta: She'd like to be free, too, but she's not sure.

Therapist: If she were sure and she felt free, what would she rather do?

Greta: She liked to relax, ya know? She likes the beach, lying in the sun, jumping in the water. I grew up near the beach.

Therapist: Sounds great. Maybe she'd like to watch you with the three-year-old this week and then decide if it would be safe to take a break at the beach.

Greta: Yeah. She likes that idea. But she wants me to find a new job.

Therapist: What do you think?

Greta: (*She nods thoughtfully.*) I think she's right. It's time.



However painful their experiences, exiles revive when they get what they need: a secure relationship with a trustworthy, responsive adult. Protective teams can spend years being convinced that a fragile exile is the client and that they are the sole resource for safety. They believe that helping that exile involves moving mountains. That it would take an army, a trainload of equipment, and a magic wand! They wonder how there could be any help from inside this bereft system because they have no sense of the Self, no access to their lifeboat. Yet being heard and feeling validated is just the evidence managers and firefighters need that the Self exists. If the Self can accept and hold them in positive regard, they feel reassured that it can do the same for wounded exiles.

BACKLASH

Sometimes a piece of sensitive work will activate protective parts who are very accustomed to running the show. In what we call *backlash*, they get back in the driver's seat and find ways to distance the client from their recent exposure to wounded parts and memories of bad experiences. Backlash happens when protectors are still scared of returning to the exile's story and being overwhelmed by its feelings. It can also occur when an exile feels desperately let down because the client made a promise and didn't follow through.

It's important to understand that backlash will happen with all clients and with any kind of addictive process. Typically, it involves a familiar set of protective parts taking over. For example, firefighters might ignite a craving and lure the client in the direction of pills, gambling, or pornography. Managers might then weigh in, berating the client and criticizing everything they do (or don't do) as wrong. This inner polarity unsettles exiles, igniting their shamefulness and hopelessness. It makes clients worry that they can't change or that their parts won't let them change. But backlash is part of the process. Our job is to stay calm, reassuring, and optimistic.

As we help the client identify this addictive cycle, we interview protectors to discover what they feared would happen if they didn't take over, which helps them unblend. As they reconnect with the Self, they remember they're not alone and don't have to solve all client's problems. At the same time, we ask the client if they noticed any of their exiles during the week. If so, we make a plan for those parts to go to a safe place between sessions if they're willing, and we encourage the client to check in